
Paper 2, Option 2E.1: Mao's China, 1949–76

Overview

This option comprises a study in depth of the transformation of communist China in the years 1949–76. The aftershocks of these changes are still being felt today as China emerges as a great economic and political power on the world stage.

Students will gain an in-depth understanding of the nature and extent of change in this period, the effects of Mao Zedong's policies on the lives of the Chinese people, and Mao's role in driving dramatic political, social and economic changes.

Key topics	Content
1 Establishing communist rule	• China in 1949: the aftermath of the civil war of 1946–49; the state of China's industry, agriculture and national infrastructure. • The new power structure; the different roles of the CCP, the government, the bureaucracy and the People's Liberation Army (PLA); Mao's dominant position within government; the growth of democratic centralism. • Defeating the CCP's opponents: the 'three antis' and 'five antis' movements; the use of terror against opponents of Communist rule; the reunification campaigns in Tibet, Xinjiang and Guangdong; the development of the Laogai system. The Hundred Flowers campaign 1957 and aftermath to 1965. • China and the Korean War: its role in enhancing CCP control, suppressing opposition, and promoting national unity; the human and financial costs of intervention in Korea; China's enhanced international prestige.
2 Agriculture and industry, 1949–65	• Early changes in agriculture, 1949–57: attacks on landlordism; the redistribution of land; moves towards agricultural cooperation; the change from voluntary to enforced collectivisation. • The communes and their organisation; communal living; the abolition of private farming; Lysenkoism; the Great Famine of 1958–62; the restoration of private farming by Liu Shaoqi and Deng Xiaoping. • The First Five-Year Plan, 1952–56: the USSR's financial and technical support; the plan's targets, successes and failures. • The Second Five-Year Plan (the Great Leap Forward), 1958–62: Mao's reasons for launching it; state-owned enterprises; the successes and failures of the second Plan. The Lushan Conference 1959. Liu, Deng and economic reform, 1962–65.

Key topics	Content
3 The Cultural Revolution and its aftermath, 1966–76	• Mao's reasons for launching the Cultural Revolution: divisions within the CCP between ideologues and pragmatists; the quest for permanent revolution; attacks on the bureaucracy; the divisions within the CCP between supporters and opponents of Mao's policies. • The Red Guards and Red Terror: Mao's hold on young people; the mass rallies of 1966; Red Guard attacks on the 'four olds' (culture, customs, habits, ideas); the growth of anarchy and the use of terror; cultural destruction. • Attacks on Mao's political and class enemies: Liu Shaoqi and Deng Xiaoping; Lin Biao; the purging of the CCP membership; 'capitalist roaders' and foreigners living in China. • Winding down the Cultural Revolution, 1968–76: restoration of order by the PLA; 'up to the mountains and down to the villages' campaign; the return to power of Deng Xiaoping and Zhou Enlai; reining in the Gang of Four. The death of Mao.
4 Social and cultural changes, 1949–76	• The changing status of women: foot binding; the Marriage Law 1950; the impact of collectivisation and the communes on women's lives; women and the family; the nature and extent of change; the problem of changing traditional views, especially in the countryside. • Education and health provision: the growth of literacy; Pinyin; the collapse of education after 1966; the barefoot doctors; successes and failures of healthcare reform. • Cultural change: attacks on traditional culture in towns and countryside; the role of Jiang Qing; the imposition of revolutionary art and culture. • Religion: attacks on Buddhism, Confucianism, Christianity, Islam and ancestor worship.